1.1 Shots at Fort Sumter

Imagine a hot, dry landscape where rain hasn't fallen for months. It would take only a spark to send the whole area up in flames. The spark that ignited the Civil War was the attack on Fort Sumter.

MAIN IDEA Once the northern states declared war and most southern states had seceded, the country waited to see whether the states in between would remain in the Union.

THE SPARK THAT CAUSED THE FIRE

As you have read, President Abraham Lincoln declared that secession was illegal under the Constitution. Southerners, on the other hand, claimed secession as a states' right guaranteed by the document. They decided to secede because they perceived Lincoln's election as a threat to the lawful institution of slavery.

After they split from the Union, the newly formed Confederate states declared that everything owned by the U.S. government within their boundaries now belonged to the Confederacy. Fort Sumter in Charleston, South Carolina, was among the possessions they claimed.

Union major **Robert Anderson**, who was in charge of the fort, had watched the people of Charleston get swept up in secession fever, and he was worried. More than 5,000 Confederate soldiers surrounded Anderson and his men, and the Union soldiers were so low on provisions that they faced starvation. Lincoln sent a message to the southern leaders stating that he was going to send food, but not weapons, to the soldiers at Fort Sumter.

On April 11, 1861, before the Union's provisions arrived, Confederate leaders demanded that the Union troops **evacuate**, or leave, the fort. Otherwise, Confederate forces would take the stronghold by force. Lincoln and Anderson refused to agree to this demand, and the next day, Confederate forces began bombarding the fort from all sides. The shelling lasted for 34 hours. On April 14, with no more food or ammunition, Anderson surrendered.

War was unpopular among northerners, but the attack stirred the Union to action. Lincoln declared South Carolina to be in rebellion and called to form a militia. The Civil War had begun. Its purpose then was not to end slavery but to reunite the nation.



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AMERICAN PLACES

Fort Sumter

Fort Sumter was built after the War of 1812 with Britain had revealed the need for added defense along the U.S. coast. The five-sided island fort was designed to protect Charleston Harbor. No one was killed during the 1861 bombardment of the fort, but two Union soldiers accidentally died during a 100-gun salute.



THE GEOGRAPHY OF WAR

Within two days of Lincoln's call to arms, Virginia seceded. The Confederacy established its capital at Richmond, Virginia. Soon after, Arkansas, Tennessee, and North Carolina left the Union. However, four states bordering both the Union and the Confederacy—Maryland, Delaware, Missouri, and Kentucky—remained undecided. These states, called the **border states**, lay in the middle ground between the warring North and South and so were very important geographically.

Maryland, for example, bordered Washington, D.C., on three sides. If the state joined the Confederacy, the Union's capital would be completely surrounded by Confederate states. In an effort to keep Maryland in the Union, Lincoln threatened to jail any Confederate soldier who entered the state.

Missouri was also vital to the Union cause. With its large population, Missouri could supply the Union with many soldiers. The state also produced a great deal of food and protected the western side of the Union. In addition, its biggest city, St. Louis, was an important commercial and transportation center.

In Kentucky, both Confederate recruiters and pro-Union leaders tried to sway the state's citizens. But when Confederate forces invaded Kentucky in September 1861, the state asked the federal government for help. Lincoln sent troops to the state, the invaders were driven out, and Kentucky stayed in the Union.

The president gained more ground when 50 counties in northwest Virginia decided to form a new state. The people in those counties no longer wanted to be a part of pro-slavery Virginia and so, in 1863, West Virginia became part of the Union. Overall, Lincoln succeeded in keeping the border states in the Union. He would need all the forces he could gather to prepare for war and fight the long, tough battles ahead.

HISTORICAL THINKING

1. **READING CHECK** What happened after the Confederates attacked Fort Sumter?
2. **SUMMARIZE** Why was it important for the Union to keep the border states out of the Confederacy?
3. **IDENTIFY PROBLEMS AND SOLUTIONS** How did Lincoln deal with Confederate attempts to seize the border states?

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